

Toki Pona — An Unofficial Primer

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Important

Toki Pona was created by Sonja Lang in the early 2000s and was released to the public. It has been modified and expanded by Lang and a growing community of enthusiasts ever since. This document is my own, but I have no claim on Toki Pona itself. This is simply a compilation of my notes and learning about Toki Pona as I currently understand it. This is by no means authoritative.

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Forword

Toki Pona is a minimalist constructed language with ~120–140 words and simple grammar. Its name means roughly “*good language*” or “*simple language*.” It is intended to be fun to speak and flexible—designed to foster positive thoughts and interactions.

This guide covers grammar, key phrases, the full word list, and how to convert English names. It is intended to be a helpful guide for beginners and a useful reference for speakers at all levels. It is not a substitute for a structured course or textbook—no exercises, lessons, or guided progression are included.

If you are serious about studying Toki Pona, I’ve included a few links to more “official” sources at the end of this document.

Essential Vocabulary

If you want to get going quickly, these words are—in my estimation—the least you need.

Word	Meaning	Notes
mi	me, I, we	1st person pronoun
sina	you	2nd person pronoun
ona	he, she, it, they	3rd person pronoun
ni	this, that	demonstrative pronoun
jan	person	
soweli	animal, creature	
toki	language, communication	
ante	difference, opposite	
lon	in/at/on; to exist	
pali	to do, make, work	
kama	to become, becoming, became	
wile	to want, to need	
jo	to have	
pana	to give	
sona	knowledge, to know	
tawa	to go, travel, movement	
tan	from, originates in	
ali	all, everything	
ala	no, nothing, zero	
mute	many, a lot	
open	open, start	
pake *	stop	
pini	finish, end	
suli	big, tall, important	
lili	small, young, unimportant	
seme	(question word)	
e	(introduces direct object)	
la	(context marker)	
pi	(groups words into a modifier phrase)	

* *pake* is an uncommon word. *pini* is a core word, but its meaning is different enough that I believe *pake* is the best choice in this case.

Grammar

Basic Sentence Structure

X li [B] Y [e Z] [C W]

Part	Role
X	Subject
li	Predicate marker
B	Preverb (optional)
Y	Predicate
e	Direct-object marker
Z	Direct object (optional)
C	Preposition (optional)
W	Additional phrase (optional)

Pronouns

Used for both singular and plural.

Word	Meaning	Notes
mi	I, me, we	Omit li
sina	you	Omit li
ona	he, she, it, they	Use li
ni	this, that	Use li

Tip

mi and sina **never** take li — the predicate follows directly.

mi kama. mi lukin. mi pakala — *"I came, I saw, I conquered."*

Predicates

The predicate is what the subject **is** or **does**. It can be:

- An **action**—working, playing, talking
- A **description**—blue, good, tall
- A **thing**—a house, an animal, food

Preverbs

Placed *before* the predicate: X li <preverb> Y

Word	Meaning
awen	continuous state
kama	became / is becoming / will become
ken	to be able to
lukin	to try to see or notice
sona	to know how to
wile	to want / to need

Tip

mi sona = “I know” vs. mi kama sona = “I’m learning” (moving toward knowledge)

Direct Object

Marked by **e**. The thing the action is done **to**.

- soweli li pali e tomo waso — “The animal builds a nest.”
- mi lukin e mun — “I watch the stars.”
- mi moku kili = I eat fruit (general) vs. mi moku e kili = I’m eating fruit (specific)

Prepositions

Further modify predicates with location, manner, reason, etc.

Word	Meaning
kepeken	making use of, by way of
lon	location in relation to something
sama	similar/equal to
tan	the origin of, because of
tawa	towards, from the perspective of

Tip

Use **lon** before a relational word to identify a spatial relationship.

soweli li lon insa tomo — *"The animal is in the house."*

Particles

Small words with grammatical functions.

Word	Function
anu	either/or (combines subjects or predicates)
e	marks the direct object
en	and (combines multiple subjects)
la	context marker
li	marks the predicate
o	command or vocative
pi	marks a modifier phrase

li — Predicate Marker

Omitted only when the subject is **mi** or **sina**.

- soweli li suwi — *"The animal is cute."*
- ona li pali mute li lape lili — *"They work a lot and sleep a bit."* (multiple predicates: repeat li)

e — Direct Object Marker

X li Y e Z = X does Y to Z

- soweli li pakala e kasi — *“The animal breaks the plant.”*

pi — Modifier Phrase

Groups multiple words into a single modifier for the head noun.

- poki pi telo wawa — *“strong-liquid container”* (e.g. a coffee cup)
- poki telo wawa — *“strong liquid container”* (e.g. a diamond bottle)

o — Command / Vocative

Replaces **li** for commands, wishes, or desires. The subject **sina** can be omitted in direct commands.

- [sina] o tawa pona — *“Drive carefully!”*
- ona o lape — *“They should sleep.”*
- jan Su o lape pona — *“Hey Su, sleep well!”*

la — Context Marker

X la Y = *In the context of X, Y*

- tenpo lon la mi sitelen e lipu sona — *“Right now, I write a knowledge-document.”*
- mi la ni li pona — *“As for me, this is nice.”*

en — Subject Combiner

Always omitted for the **first** subject.

- jan en soweli li sama mute — *“People and animals are very similar.”*

anu — Either/Or

- waso anu kala li tawa — *“The bird or the fish moves.”*
- Use to ask either/or questions: telo suli anu telo lili ni = *“Is this the ocean or a lake?”*

Pseudo-Particles

Words that mostly act as particles but can function in other ways too.

Word	Meaning
ala	negation, nothingness
kin	also, too
nanpa	number, ordinal
taso	only, but

ala — Negation

Append to negate a phrase.

- mi pali ala — *"I will not work."*
- mi ken ala toki — *"I cannot speak."*

nanpa — Ordinal / Number

- ilo pi akesi suwi nanpa wan — *"the first lizard's tool"*
- ilo nanpa wan pi akesi suwi — *"the lizard's first tool"*

kin — Also / Too

- jan li ken pona kin — *"People can also be peaceful."*
- ona kin li tawa sona — *"They too gain knowledge."*

taso — Only / But

- soweli li ken pona taso — *"Animals can only be good."*
- taso ma li sike e suno — *"But, the earth revolves around the sun."*
- ona li taso — *"They are alone."*

How to Say "And"

There is no direct word for "and." Use these constructions:

Situation	Construction	Example
Multiple subjects	en	X1 en X2 li Y
Multiple predicates	repeat li	X li Y1 li Y2
Multiple predicates with mi/sina	separate sentences	mi Y1. mi Y2.
Multiple direct objects	repeat e	X li Y e Z1 e Z2

Questions

Method	Construction	Meaning
Yes/no	X li Y ala Y	"Is X Y?"
Either/or	X li Y anu seme	"Is X Y, or what?"
Open	X li seme	"What is/does X?"
Object	X li Y e seme	"What does X Y?"

Negation

Append ala to the predicate:

- mi tawa ala — "I will not go."
- mi lon ala tomo — "I am not in the house."

Comparison

Toki Pona offers several ways to compare one thing to another:

- Put two short comparative sentences one after another.
 - jan Emily li sulì. jan Trisha li lili — "Emily is bigger than Trisha."
- Use la to present one item in the context of another:
 - tomo mi la tomo sina li loje mute — "Compared to my house, your house is more red."
- Use tawa, in the sense of "to," to express perspective.
 - kala ni li lili tawa waso ni — "That fish is small to that bird."
- Use lon poka (next to) for physical comparison:
 - kili ni li sulì lon poka lawa mi — "This fruit is big next to my head."

5. For superlatives, declare something **nanpa wan** (number one):

- **toki ni li pona nanpa wan a** — *"This is the best language."*

Transitive Statements

X li Y e Z can mean:

1. **X applies Y to Z** — **mi pona e tomo** → *"I repair the house."*
2. **X causes Z to become Y** — **mi tomo e waso** → *"I turn the bird into a house."*

Interjections & Emoticle

a is the *emoticle* (emotion + particle) — append to any word or phrase to indicate excitement or emphasis.

- **pona a** — *"So nice!"*
- **wawa tawa sina a** — *"May the force be with you!"*

Example Phrases

Toki Pona handles concepts without direct translations by stacking words into descriptive phrases. Some of these are my own coinages—not community-established terms—but they show the pattern clearly.

Toki Pona	English
mi wile taso e pona sina	<i>I just want to help you</i>
mi sona	<i>I know</i>
mi kama sona	<i>I'm learning</i>
mi wile e ni: moku pona	<i>I want good food</i>
tenpo lon la mi sitelen e lipu sona	<i>Right now, I write a knowledge-document</i>
soweli li pali e tomo waso	<i>The animal builds a nest</i>
mi lukin e mun	<i>I watch the stars</i>
soweli li sona ala	<i>Cryptid (unknown creature)</i>
soweli jan li linja mute	<i>Bigfoot/Sasquatch</i>
monsuta li telo lili	<i>Lake monster</i>

Full Word List

Core Words (pu)

The core 120 words from “Toki Pona: The Language of Good” by Sonja Lang.

Word	Meaning
a	(exclamation), ah!
akesi	reptile, lizard, amphibian
ala	no, nothing, zero
alasa	hunt, search
ale / ali	all, everything
anpa	bottom, below
ante	difference, opposite
anu	either/or
awen	wait, sustain
e	(introduces direct object)
en	and, plus
esun	shop
ijo	thing, stuff
ike	bad, evil
ilo	device, tool
insa	inside
jaki	gross
jan	person
jelo	yellow
jo	to have
kala	fish
kalama	sound, noise
kama	to come
kasi	plant
ken	can, able to
kepeken	to make use of
kili	fruit, vegetables
kiwen	hard, solid
ko	soft, goo
kon	air, wind, soul

Word	Meaning
kule	color
kulupu	group, community
kute	listen, ear
la	(context marker)
lape	sleep
laso	blue
lawa	head, leadership
len	clothing
lete	cold
li	(between subject and predicate)
lili	small
linja	string, rope
lipu	document, page
loje	red
lon	in/at/on, to exist
luka	hand
lukin	see, look
lupa	opening, portal
ma	land, outside
mama	parent
mani	money
meli	female
mi	me, I, we
mije	male
moku	food, eat
moli	dead
monsi	butt, back
mu	(animal sounds)
mun	moon
musi	entertainment
mute	many, a lot
nanpa	number
nasa	silly, crazy
nasin	road, path
nenā	hill, bump

Word	Meaning
ni	this, that
nimi	word, name
noka	leg, foot
o	Oh! Hey!
olin	love
ona	he, she, it, they
open	open, start
pakala	mistake, destruction
pali	to do, make
palisa	rod, stick
pan	grain
pana	to give
pi	of (group multiple words into a modifier phrase)
pilin	emotion, feel
pimeja	black
pini	finish, end
pipi	bug
poka	side, beside, hip
poki	container
pona	good, simple
pu	"Toki Pona: The Language of Good" by Sonja Lang
sama	same, equal
seli	fire, heat
selo	skin, outer layer, boundary
seme	(question word)
sewi	above, top
sijelo	body, form
sike	circle, round
sin	new, fresh
sina	you
sinpin	front, wall
sitelen	writing, image
sona	knowledge, to know
soweli	animal, creature
suli	big, important

Word	Meaning
suno	sun, light
supa	platform, flat surface
suwi	sweet, cute
tan	from, origin
taso	only, sole
tawa	to go, travel, movement
telo	water, fluid
tenpo	time
toki	language, communication
tomo	house, building
tu	two
unpa	sex (act)
uta	mouth
utala	conflict, battle
walo	white
wan	one, union
waso	bird, winged creature
wawa	energy, power
weka	to remove, absent
wile	to want, need

Extended / Community Words (ku & newer)

Widely used words included in the “Toki Pona Dictionary” by Sonja Lang, many of which were introduced by the Toki Pona enthusiast community.

Word	Meaning
epiku	epic
jasima	reverse, opposite, mirror
kin	also, too (emphasis)
kipisi	split
ku	“Toki Pona Dictionary” by Sonja Lang
lanpan	steal
leko	square, block
linluwi	network

Word	Meaning
majuna	old
meso	average, medium
misikeke	medicine
monsuta	monster
n	uh-huh
namako	spice, extra
oko	eye
soko	fungus
su	illustrated story books by Sonja Lang
tonsi	non-binary person

Experimental / Marginal Words

Lesser-used words. Most of these were also included in the “Toki Pona Dictionary” but have not become widely used.

There are many more words that could be included; these are the ones I believe have merit, or simply like.

Word	Meaning
apeja	shame, guilt
isipin	to think, brainstorm
jami	yummy, pleasurable
kamalawala	revolution
kapesi	brown, gray
kiki	spiky
kijetesantakalu	raccoon (intended to be humorous)
likujo	gathering
melome	lesbian
mijomi	gay
nimisin	a new or humorous Toki Pona word
oke	OK (an expression of acknowledgement)
pake	stop
powe	fake, pretend
soto	left (direction)

Word	Meaning
te	open quote
teje	right (direction)
to	close quote
usawi	magic, occult, supernatural
wa	(interjection of awe or surprise)

Name Rules

Identifying Proper Names

Proper names are capitalized and always begin with an identifying, lowercase noun. The identifier calls out the kind of thing being named.

Common Identifiers

Identifier	Meaning
jan	person
soweli	animal
akesi	reptile
tomo	building
ma	country/city/town

Name Conversion

Toki Pona uses a specific set of rules to phonetically adapt names from other languages.

Allowed Letters

a e i j k l m n o p s t u w

Letter Substitutions

Original	Toki Pona
b	p
d	t
f	p
g	k
r (trilled/tapped)	l
r (English approximant)	w
r (uvular/velar, e.g. French)	k

Original	Toki Pona
v	w
y	j
z	s

Syllable Structure

Syllables follow the pattern: **(C)V(n)** — optional consonant, a vowel, optional *n*

Disallowed syllables:

Disallowed	Replace with
ji, jin	drop or adjust
ti, tin	si, sin
wo, wu	o, u
nm, nn	simplify
sh (end of word)	si
th	t or s

Style Notes

- **Preserve syllable count** — drop a consonant rather than add a new vowel.
- **Approximants** (j, w) in consonant clusters can become a syllable or be dropped.
- **w or j** can be inserted as euphonic glides to preserve syllable structure.
- **Consonant clusters** — retain the dominant plosive; drop fricatives (s) and laterals (l) first.
- Sometimes **rearranging letter order** is better than dropping a sound.

Example Names

These are my attempts at converting names to Toki Pona.

English Name	Toki Pona
Jeremiah D Clark	jan Jelemija T Kalak
John Patrick Smith	jan Jon Pawik Smit
Trisha Scott Butler	jan Tinsa Sot Putjew

English Name	Toki Pona
Luna (cat)	soweli Luna
Markus (dog)	soweli Makus
Reptar (lizard)	akesi Wepjar

Further Reading:

- tokipona.org — The official website of Toki Pona and its creator, Sonja Lang
 - linku.la — A comprehensive index of known and proposed Toki Pona words
 - sona.pona.la — An extensive wiki covering topics related to Toki Pona
-

pona tawa sina a — Good luck to you!